

10 (+3) Ways to Be a Better (Technical) Interviewer

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| Why most technical interviews are broken

- No training provided — most interviewers wing it
- Different candidates get completely different interviews
- Decisions driven by gut feel, not evidence
- One careless question can expose your company to legal risk
- The candidate experience reflects your entire company

PART 1

Before the Interview

Write your questions down before the interview

- Build a question bank for each role
- Pick your questions from it deliberately
- Write them down — then stick to them
- Intentional starting points, not improvised ones

What a question bank looks like

Category	Instruction
System Design	Pick 1 of 3 prepared questions
Debugging / Problem Solving	Pick 1 of 2 prepared questions
Behavioral	Ask all 3 — every candidate
Culture / Collaboration	Pick 1 of 2 prepared questions
Candidate Q&A	Reserve 10 min — every candidate

Question bank: sample entries

Category	Example question
System Design	Design a rate limiter for a public API. What trade-offs are you making?
Debugging	A service returning errors for 5% of requests since yesterday's deploy. Walk me through your investigation.
Behavioral	Tell me about a time you disagreed with a technical decision your team made. What happened?
Behavioral	Describe a project that didn't go as planned. What would you do differently?
Behavioral	Tell me about getting up to speed on an unfamiliar codebase under time pressure.
Culture / Collab	Describe the best team you've ever been part of. What made it work?

Use the same questions for every candidate

- Core questions stay fixed — follow-ups can vary
- Consistency is your fairness guarantee
- It's also your legal protection if a decision is challenged
- "We asked every candidate the same questions" is defensible. "I went with my gut" is not.

Ad-hoc (inconsistent)

Candidate A: Asked about Redis caching (saw it on resume)

Candidate B: Asked about SQL indexing (felt relevant)

Candidate C: Asked about system design (ran out of other ideas)

Candidate D: Asked about a recent blog post you read

Result: No shared baseline. Comparison is impossible.

Consistent baseline (correct)

All candidates: Same system design Q

All candidates: Same debugging Q

All candidates: Same 3 behavioral Qs

Follow-ups vary based on their answers

Result: Fair comparison. Defensible decision.

Know what "good" looks like before the candidate walks in

- Write your scoring rubric before the interview — not after
- Define weak, average, and strong answers for each question
- Use behavioral descriptions, not evaluative ones
- A "5" is not "gave the answer I had in my head"

Rubric: System design question

Score	What it looks like
1	Can't identify the core problem; jumps to a solution with no reasoning
3	Identifies the problem, proposes a reasonable solution, misses some edge cases
5	Identifies the problem, proposes a solution, proactively calls out trade-offs, asks clarifying questions before diving in

"Tell me about a time you disagreed with a technical decision."

Score	What it looks like
1	Vague or hypothetical answer. Can't name a specific situation. Blames others with no self-reflection.
3	Describes a real situation. Explains their position. Outcome is mentioned but learning is unclear.
5	Specific situation, specific actions taken, articulates what they learned or would do differently. Shows they can disagree and still commit.

PART 2

Running the Interview

Tell the candidate exactly what to expect at the start

- Spend 2 minutes at the start giving a roadmap
- Tell them how long, what format, whether help is available
- Tell them when they'll have time for their own questions
- Reduces anxiety → better performance → better signal



"Here's how today works. We'll spend about 10 minutes on your background. Then 25 minutes on a technical problem — think of it as collaborative, I'm here to help if you get stuck. Then 10 minutes for your questions. Sound good?"

— Your opening, every time

Every sentence in the roadmap does a job

What you say	Why it matters
"Here's how today works."	Signals you're organized and have done this before
"10 minutes on your background."	Gives them time to prepare mentally, not be caught off guard
"Think of it as collaborative."	Reframes the dynamic from interrogation to conversation
"I'm here to help if you get stuck."	Gives permission to ask for help — crucial for better signal
"10 minutes for your questions."	Shows you value their evaluation of you, not just the reverse
"Sound good?"	Invites buy-in — small but humanizing

Stop interviewing for trivia — interview for thinking

- Trivia tests whether someone memorized a fact
- Thinking questions reveal how someone actually works
- Trivia has one right answer — thinking questions have a space of good answers
- Trivia advantages people who recently crammed, not people who can do the job

Trivia → Thinking

Trivia (don't ask)	Thinking (ask this instead)
"What is a deadlock?"	"Walk me through a time you had to reason about a deadlock."
"TCP vs UDP — what's the difference?"	"You're designing a multiplayer game — which would you use and why?"
"What does SOLID stand for?"	"Tell me about a codebase that was hard to change. What made it that way?"
"What is a mutex?"	"Two threads, same variable. Walk me through what could go wrong."

Trivia → Thinking: by role

Role	Trivia version	Thinking version
Frontend	What is the virtual DOM?	A user reports a page feels sluggish. Walk me through how you'd investigate.
Backend	What HTTP status codes do you know?	You need to design an error response strategy for a public API. What decisions do you make?
Data / ML	What is overfitting?	You deploy a model and accuracy drops in production. What do you look at first?
DevOps	What is a Kubernetes pod?	A deployment is failing intermittently in prod but not staging. How do you approach it?
Staff / Lead	What is Conway's Law?	Describe a time the team structure affected the architecture. What did you do about it?

Shut up and wait

- After asking a question, count silently to ten before saying anything
- 0–5 seconds: normal cognitive processing
- 5–10 seconds: deep thinking, formulating a structured answer
- 10+ seconds: now it's appropriate to check in
- We fill silence because we're uncomfortable — not because the candidate is stuck

Jumps in too soon

5 seconds of silence...

"So maybe think about the data layer first?"

"Or you could consider caching?"

→ You've now given away the answer.
The candidate's response is no longer theirs.

Waits, then checks in well

10 seconds of silence...

"What are you thinking about right now?"

→ Invites them to narrate their process
without solving it for them.

→ You learn how they think under pressure.

Take notes during the interview, not after

- Memory is unreliable — especially after back-to-back interviews
- You'll remember your impression far better than what actually happened
- Impressions are where bias lives
- Keep notes behavioral, not evaluative

Evaluative vs. behavioral notes

Evaluative (don't write this)	Behavioral (write this instead)
"Seemed confused"	"Couldn't articulate the difference between their two proposed approaches"
"Good communicator"	"Explained the trade-off unprompted, used an analogy that made it clear"
"Struggled with the hard part"	"Got brute force quickly, got stuck when asked to optimize"
"Felt like a culture fit"	"Asked two questions about team process, one about how failure is handled"

What good interview notes look like

DID WELL

Asked two clarifying questions before touching the design. Identified the read-heavy vs write-heavy distinction unprompted. Used an analogy (airport check-in) that made caching intuitive.

GOT STUCK

Couldn't articulate trade-offs between eventual consistency and strong consistency. When asked to optimize, paused for ~15 sec then asked for a hint.

RESPONSE TO HINTS

Hint about CAP theorem landed well — picked it up quickly and extended it. Didn't get defensive.

THEIR QUESTIONS

Asked about on-call expectations. Asked how the team handles post-mortems. Didn't ask about salary or PTO.

Know which questions are illegal

Most illegal questions aren't malicious — they come from small talk and curiosity. Intent doesn't matter. Legal exposure is real.

The rule: Am I asking about the job — or about their life? If it's the latter, stop.

Protected categories with examples

Category	What NOT to ask
Age	"What year did you graduate?" / "How long until you retire?"
Family / Marital status	"Do you have kids?" / "Are you planning a family?"
National origin	"Where are you originally from?" / "Is that a [country] accent?"
Religion	"Do you observe any holidays we should know about?"
Disability	"Do you have any health conditions that would affect the job?"
Pregnancy	Anything. Don't.

Illegal question → Legal version

What you're really worried about	Illegal way to ask it	Legal way to ask it
Can they work weekends?	"Do you have family commitments on weekends?"	"This role sometimes requires weekend availability. Can you accommodate that?"
Are they authorized to work here?	"Where are you originally from?"	"Are you legally authorized to work in [country]?"
Will a condition affect performance?	"Do you have any health issues?"	"Here are the physical requirements of the role. Can you meet these with or without reasonable accommodation?"
Will they need lots of holidays?	"What religion are you?"	"Are you able to meet the attendance requirements for this role?"

PART 3

After the Interview

Debrief before you talk to each other

- Everyone writes their independent assessment before the group discussion
- Score first. Talk second.
- Go around the room — share score and top observation before open discussion
- If you're the most senior person in the room, share your score last

Pre-debrief scorecard template

Candidate _____

Role _____

Interviewer _____

Date _____

OVERALL RECOMMENDATION

☐ Strong hire ☐ Hire ☐ No hire ☐ Strong no hire

TOP OBSERVATION (BEHAVIORAL)

e.g. 'Asked clarifying questions before designing, called out CAP theorem trade-off unprompted'

BIGGEST CONCERN

e.g. 'Struggled to explain why — gave correct answer but couldn't defend it when probed'

SCORE (1–5)

____ / 5

Give every candidate feedback — even the ones you reject

- Three sentences. One specific observation. One genuine positive. One good wish.
- It's rare — which means it's remembered
- The technical community is small
- The way you treat candidates is your employer brand in action



"Your system design instincts were strong, but we wanted to see more depth reasoning through failure modes and edge cases — something that comes with experience. We appreciated how clearly you communicated throughout. We wish you well."

— Three sentences. Specific. Honest. Kind.

The three-sentence structure

Sentence	Purpose	Example
1 — Specific constructive observation	Tells them something actionable they can work on	"We wanted to see more depth when reasoning through failure modes."
2 — Genuine positive	Acknowledges real signal — not hollow praise	"Your system design instincts and communication were strong."
3 — Good wish	Closes with dignity	"We wish you well in your search."

PART 4 — BONUS

Remote Interviewing

Set up your remote environment like it matters

- Camera at eye level — not looking up your nose
- Light source in front of you, not behind
- Headset or dedicated mic — laptop audio is almost always bad
- Close Slack, email, anything that generates notifications
- Join 2 minutes early — a candidate waiting in a lobby starts the interview in a hole

Before you let the candidate in

Item	What to check	Done
Camera	At eye level — prop your laptop on books if needed	☐
Lighting	Lamp or window in front of you — not behind you	☐
Audio	Headset or external mic — test it before they join	☐
Background	Neutral, uncluttered — or plain virtual background	☐
Notifications	Slack, email, Teams all closed or on Do Not Disturb	☐
Questions	Your question bank open and ready — not scrambling on the fly	☐
Join early	In the room 2 min early — candidate shouldn't be waiting alone	☐

Decide your AI policy before the interview — then tell the candidate

- AI use during interviews is the elephant in the room right now
- Candidates don't know if they're allowed. Interviewers haven't aligned. Everyone's guessing.
- Make a deliberate team decision. Document it. Communicate it at the start.
- The mistake isn't which policy you choose — it's not having one

Three defensible AI policies

Policy	What to say	Best for
AI allowed	"Use any tools you'd normally use on the job."	Roles where AI use is expected day-to-day
AI not allowed	"Work without AI tools — we want to understand your baseline thinking."	Assessing foundational knowledge
AI allowed, but narrate	"Use AI if you want, but talk me through what you're doing and why."	Usually the most revealing option

Recognize AI-assisted answers — and respond productively

Signs to watch for:

- Answer arrives unusually fast and polished — no hesitation, no thinking out loud
- Language is formal or generic compared to how they speak otherwise
- They can state a solution but struggle to explain why it works
- When you change a constraint, they stall in a way that doesn't match someone who reasoned through the original

Go one level deeper — always

- "Walk me through your reasoning on that."
- "If we changed this constraint, how would your approach change?"
- "What's the part of this solution you're least confident in?"
- "What are the failure modes here?"

Someone who genuinely understands their answer handles these easily. Someone who got the answer from somewhere else usually can't.

The answer they gave

"I'd use a distributed cache with a consistent hashing ring, implement a write-through strategy, set TTLs based on access frequency, and use a circuit breaker for cache misses to prevent stampede."

*Fast. Polished. No hesitation.
Language noticeably more formal
than their earlier answers.*

The probe

"What's the part of this solution you're least confident in?"

→ If they understand it:

"Honestly, the TTL strategy — it depends heavily on access patterns we haven't measured yet."

→ If they don't:

"Um... maybe the circuit breaker part?" [long pause]

The second response tells you everything.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER

13 things. Start with 3.

The 13

BEFORE

- Write your questions down
- Same questions, every candidate
- Define "good" in advance

DURING

- Give a roadmap at the start
- Thinking questions, not trivia
- Shut up and wait
- Take behavioral notes live
- Know the illegal questions

AFTER

- Score before you debrief
- Send real feedback

REMOTE

- Set up your environment properly
- Align on AI policy first
- Probe for understanding, always

**"None of these require a tool, a budget, or sign-off from your manager.
They require intention."**

Pick three things. Do them in your next interview. You won't just become a better interviewer — you'll become the interviewer candidates tell other candidates about.

In a tight hiring market, that matters more than you think.

Thank you

Questions?